intend to avoid a battle, but to fight closer to a friendly port. Nelson, however, was worried that his prey was going to escape him and urgently sought to engage the combined fleet.

Through the morning the British sorted themselves into two groups, one (to windward) led by Nelson on *Victory* and the other (to leeward) led by Vice Admiral Collingwood on the 100-gun *Royal Sovereign*. They bore down at a right-angle to the line of the combined fleet. It was a day of light wind and the British ships, painted with a yellow and black checker pattern to distinguish them from the enemy, made slow progress.

As the fleets closed Nelson hoisted a series of signals, including the famous "England expects that every man will do his duty." Once the fighting finally started, the terrifying risks involved in Nelson's battle plan became plainly evident. Aiming to cross the line behind Villeneuve's flagship *Bucentaure* in the French-Spanish center, *Victory* was under fire from enemy broadsides for 40 minutes during its agonizingly slow approach, able to reply only with its few forward guns. Collingwood's faster *Royal Sovereign* took less punishment approaching the enemy line but was then isolated, fighting five enemy ships at once while slower British ships came up to join her. Yet both flagships made excellent use of the opportunity presented by cutting the line. *Victory* raked *Bucentaure* with a devastating broadside through its stern that killed almost 200 men. *Royal Sovereign* did the same to *Santa Anna*, flagship of Spanish admiral Alava, causing some 400 casualties at a stroke.

As more British ships came up, the pell-mell battle Nelson had envisaged developed in the center and rear of the French-Spanish line. In a series of close engagements the British used superior gunnery to batter the French and Spanish ships, causing huge casualties and silencing their guns. The French and Spanish fired high to dismast British ships, which they then tried to board.

Santisima Trinidad surrenders
The Battle of Trafalgar at 3:00 p.m: on the left, with her masts destroyed, the Spanish flagship *Santisima Trinidad* (painted orange) surrenders to *Neptune*. At the time she was the largest warship in the world.

1758–1805

HORATIO NELSON

BRITISH ADMIRAL



Although Nelson's father was an undistinguished Norfolk clergyman, the family had excellent connections in British naval administration. At sea from the age of 12, Nelson became the youngest captain in the Royal Navy in 1779. He saw service in the Caribbean during the American Revolutionary War, but it was his performance during the French Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars that brought him undying fame. Nelson was particularly recognized for employing the battle tactic of cutting through the enemy's lines, which although not entirely novel, had never been adopted to such successful effect. Always leading from the front, he lost the sight of his right eye in the siege of Calvi, Corsica, in 1793 and his right arm in a raid on Tenerife four years later.

BIRTH OF A LEGEND

He first won renown for his initiative at the battle of Cape St. Vincent in 1797, and his stunning victory at the battle of the Nile in 1798 made him a national hero. Nelson's tendency to obey orders only when it suited him, displayed most famously at Copenhagen in 1801, was not to everyone's taste, and his liaison with Lady Emma Hamilton damaged his reputation, but he won the devoted admiration of the captains who served under him. After his death at Trafalgar, he was accorded a state funeral of unparalleled splendor.

Death of Nelson
Nelson dies below decks aboard HMS *Victory*, three hours after being mortally wounded by a French sniper.

